

Conscience Booklet

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How to Use This Booklet

Each topic has the same architecture. First comes an **introduction** that situates the thinker within his or her discipline and flags the live scholarly disputes. Then comes **the text** itself — read it slowly, and more than once, before you look at the questions. Finally, come **questions for study**, arranged as a deliberate ascent through four cognitive operations:

Comprehension asks what the text says. You cannot analyse what you have not first understood, and most weak examination answers fail here, at the foundation, by misreporting a thinker's actual claim.

Analysis asks how the argument works — its structure, its hidden premises, its mechanism. To analyse is to take an argument apart and see what holds it together.

Synthesis asks you to connect this thinker to others in the anthology. Conscience is a conversation across centuries; the synthesis questions force you to put the speakers in the same room and stage the argument between them.

Evaluation asks whether the argument is any good. Here you weigh objections, test consequences, and reach a defended judgement of your own.

They map onto the two OCR assessment objectives as follows: comprehension corresponds to **AO1** (knowledge and understanding), while analysis, synthesis, and evaluation constitute **AO2** (analysis and evaluation), which carries greater weight in every essay. Each question is tagged accordingly. The ladder is a heuristic, not a law: good evaluation often loops back to re-read the text.

Each topic closes with an **examination-style essay question** in the OCR idiom. Attempt these under timed conditions. A *Glossary of Key Terms* and full *Sources and Further Reading* are provided at the end.

One final instruction, which is the whole spirit of the thing: argue back. The most useful sentence you can write in the margin of any of these extracts is “but this is wrong, because —”.

Part I — Conscience as the Voice of God: The Theological Tradition

The three thinkers in this Part share a single conviction: that conscience is not finally our own, but God's — a law we discover within ourselves rather than one we author. They differ sharply on the details. Augustine makes conscience depend on grace; the Magisterium makes it a sanctuary in which the human person meets God; Newman makes it the very ground for believing that God exists at all. Read them as a developing argument, and ask at each step what work the word “God” is doing.

I. Augustine of Hippo — Conscience, Grace and the Inner Self

Introduction

Augustine of Hippo (354–430) is the hinge on which the classical and the Christian conceptions of the moral self turn. Writing in the dying decades of the Western Roman Empire, he made the *inner life* the principal theatre of the moral and religious drama — a move so consequential that the whole later tradition of “examining one’s conscience” descends from him. For Augustine the decisive moral question is never simply *what did you do?* but *from what root did the deed grow?* An act that looks virtuous may spring from pride; an act of love may be misread by onlookers. Only God, who sees the root, can judge.

Two features of his account should be held in tension. First, conscience for Augustine is **innate** — part of our God-given nature, an inner awareness of right and wrong to which we can always “return.” Second, after the Fall, that nature is so disordered by sin that, left to itself, it cannot reliably move us to the good. Hence conscience is **dependent on grace**: God’s unearned guidance is what makes the inner witness trustworthy. This is the heart of Augustine’s quarrel with Pelagius, who held that human beings can achieve righteousness by their own effort. Augustine’s anti-Pelagian conviction — that we cannot save ourselves — gives his conscience a peculiar character: it is authoritative but not self-sufficient. A further consequence follows. Because the individual conscience is fallible, it must be *formed*; and for Augustine it is the teaching of the Church, founded and sustained by Christ, that forms it. Here lies the seed of a problem that runs through this entire Part: if conscience is the voice of God, and the Church also speaks for God, what happens when they appear to disagree? Newman (Topic 3) will give that question its sharpest answer.

The text

From Augustine, Homilies on the First Epistle of John (In Epistolam Ioannis ad Parthos):**

Return to your own conscience, question it. Do not consider what blossoms outwardly, but what root there is in the ground. Is lust rooted there? A show there may be of good deeds, truly good works there cannot be. Is charity rooted there? Have no fear: nothing evil can come of that... More accepted is the blow of charity than the alms of pride. Come then within, brethren; and in all things, whatsoever ye do, look unto God your witness.

Editorial commentary (from the source anthology): While Augustine does not go into details, he seems to see conscience as an inner awareness of right and wrong which we can appeal to. As his Anti-Pelagian writings make clear, Augustine considered that since the Fall of Adam, human beings are incapable of doing any good by themselves. Accordingly, for him conscience is dependent on the grace of God — his undeserved guidance and salvation. Conscience is innate; it is part of our God-given nature. But without God’s direct gift of grace it is too corrupted by sin to enable us to act

rightly. Augustine's wider theology also reveals the relation between conscience and the Church: the teaching of the Church, which Christ has founded and sustains, informs our conscience.

Questions for study

Comprehension (*AO1 — knowledge and understanding*)

1. Explain Augustine's distinction between the "root" and the "blossom" of an action, and say why he treats the root as decisive.
2. What does the commentary mean when it says that, for Augustine, conscience is "innate" yet "dependent on the grace of God"?

Analysis (*AO2 — analysis*)

1. Augustine holds simultaneously that conscience is part of our God-given nature and that it is "too corrupted by sin" to guide us rightly without grace. Analyse this tension: in what sense can a faculty be both authoritative and untrustworthy?

Synthesis (*AO1/AO2*)

1. Compare Augustine's grace-dependent conscience with Aquinas's *synderesis*, the natural disposition that "incites to good and complains of evil" (Topic 4). Is Aquinas correcting Augustine's pessimism about human nature, or building on it?
2. Augustine locates the truth of an act in its inner root; Freud locates the origin of conscience in the internalised parent (Topic 6). Set these two "genetic" accounts side by side — what does each finally take the inner voice to *be*?

Evaluation (*AO2 — critical evaluation*)

1. "If conscience needs grace to function reliably, it cannot be a trustworthy moral guide for those without faith." Assess this objection to Augustine.
2. Evaluate whether Augustine's emphasis on hidden motive over visible action makes his ethics impossible to operate in public life, where only actions can be seen.

Examination-style essay (*AO1 + AO2*)

"Conscience is worthless without the grace of God." Discuss with reference to Augustine.

2. The Catholic Magisterium — *Gaudium et Spes* and the Catechism

Introduction

“Magisterium” is the term for the teaching authority of the Roman Catholic Church. The two documents excerpted here are its most authoritative modern statements on conscience. *Gaudium et Spes* — the *Pastoral Constitution on the Church in the Modern World* — was promulgated in 1965 by the Second Vatican Council under Pope Paul VI; the *Catechism of the Catholic Church* was promulgated in 1992 under Pope John Paul II and codifies that teaching for the universal Church. Together they show a tradition trying to hold two things at once.

On one side, conscience is exalted almost without limit. It is “man’s most secret core and his sanctuary,” a place where he is “alone with God.” This is the language of inviolability: no power, ecclesiastical or political, may force its way in. On the other side, the Catechism is strikingly *rationalist* about what conscience actually is. It is “a judgment of reason” — not a feeling, not an oracle, not a mysterious inner voice, but an act of practical intelligence applying moral knowledge to a particular case. That definition is lifted, almost intact, from Aquinas (Topic 4); the modern Magisterium is Thomist to its core, and a student who notices this can connect the specification’s named scholar directly to lived Catholic doctrine.

The most demanding teaching is §1790: a person “must always obey the certain judgment of his conscience,” even though that conscience may, through ignorance, be mistaken. Here the Church follows Aquinas to a conclusion many find uncomfortable — that the binding force of conscience does not depend on its being correct. Yet the same tradition insists conscience must be *formed*, educated by the Word of God and the teaching of the Church, lest it err culpably. The resulting structure — an inviolable sanctuary that must nonetheless be furnished from outside — is either a subtle balance of freedom and authority or, as critics allege, a quiet contradiction.

The text

From the Second Vatican Council, Gaudium et Spes (1965), §16:**

Deep within his conscience man discovers a law which he has not laid upon himself but which he must obey. Its voice, ever calling him to love and to do what is good and to avoid evil, sounds in his heart at the right moment... For man has in his heart a law inscribed by God... His conscience is man’s most secret core and his sanctuary. There he is alone with God whose voice echoes in his depths.

From the Catechism of the Catholic Church (1992):**

§1778. Conscience is a judgment of reason whereby the human person recognizes the moral quality of a concrete act that he is going to perform, is in the process of performing, or has already completed.

§1782. Man has the right to act in conscience and in freedom so as personally to make moral decisions. “He must not be forced to act contrary to his conscience. Nor must he be prevented from acting according to his conscience, especially in religious matters.”

§1790. A human being must always obey the certain judgment of his conscience. If he were deliberately to act against it, he would condemn himself. Yet it can happen that moral

conscience remains in ignorance and makes erroneous judgments about acts to be performed or already committed.

Note: §1776 of the Catechism opens its treatment of conscience by quoting the *Gaudium et Spes* passage above; and *Gaudium et Spes* in turn draws on Augustine (Topic 1), whom it cites. The chain of authority is unbroken from the fifth century to the present.

Questions for study

Comprehension (AO1)

1. According to *Gaudium et Spes*, what is the origin of the “law” a person discovers within conscience, and why is he obliged to obey it?
2. How does Catechism §1778 define conscience? Of what faculty does it make conscience an act?
3. What does §1790 require a person to do when facing “the certain judgment of his conscience,” and what does it concede about that judgment?

Analysis (AO2)

1. *Gaudium et Spes* calls conscience a “sanctuary” where man is “alone with God.” Analyse what this metaphor claims about the authority and the inviolability of conscience.
2. The Catechism defines conscience as “a judgment of reason” rather than a feeling or an inner voice. Analyse the significance of this rationalist definition.

Synthesis (AO1/AO2)

1. §1790 holds that even a mistaken conscience must be obeyed. Set this beside Aquinas on the erring conscience (Topic 4) and Newman’s toast “to Conscience first, and to the Pope afterwards” (Topic 3). Does the Magisterium follow Aquinas all the way to his conclusion?

Evaluation (AO2)

1. “To call conscience an inviolable sanctuary, and then to insist it be formed by the Church, gives with one hand and takes with the other.” Evaluate this charge of incoherence.
2. Assess whether defining conscience as “a judgment of reason” leaves the Catholic view exposed to Freud’s claim that apparent moral reasoning is really the disguised voice of internalised authority.

Examination-style essay (AO1 + AO2)

“Conscience is the voice of God, not the voice of reason.” Discuss with reference to Catholic teaching.

3. John Henry Newman — Conscience as the Echo of the Voice of God

Introduction

John Henry Newman (1801–1890) — Oxford don, leader of the Oxford Movement, convert from the Church of England to Roman Catholicism in 1845, and eventually a cardinal (he was canonised as St John Henry Newman in 2019) — gave the theological tradition its most psychologically acute account of conscience. Where Augustine emphasised grace and the Magisterium emphasised authority, Newman fastens on *experience*: the felt sense of answerability that accompanies moral failure. From that experience he builds two things at once — a theory of what conscience is, and an argument for the existence of God.

The theory is that conscience is “the echo of the voice of God.” The image is carefully chosen: “an echo implies a voice, a voice a speaker.” The phenomenon of conscience, Newman argues, points beyond itself to a Person. This is the so-called **argument from conscience**, a member of the family of moral arguments for God. Its engine is not logical deduction but *abductive inference* — an inference to the best explanation. We feel responsible, ashamed, afraid when we transgress; the best explanation of feeling answerable, Newman contends, is that there is Someone to whom we are answerable. Notice precisely where the weight falls: not on the *content* of conscience but on its *emotional grammar* of guilt and dread.

This is also where the most formidable objection lives, and it is internal to this very anthology. Freud (Topic 6) takes the identical data — guilt, the sense of being watched, the dread of punishment — and explains them entirely without God, as the pressure of an internalised parent. Newman and Freud are not discussing different things; they are rival interpreters of the same evidence. The whole question is which reading is more rational. Newman’s second great contribution concerns authority. Writing after the First Vatican Council’s definition of papal infallibility, he argued that conscience and the Pope cannot directly collide — infallibility governs general principles, conscience governs particular acts — and that, in the last resort, one must follow conscience even against the Pope. “Conscience has rights because it has duties”: it is no mere licence to please oneself, but a binding summons that may, at the limit, override the highest human authority.

The text

*From A Letter Addressed to His Grace the Duke of Norfolk** (1875), §5, “Conscience”:*

The Divine Law... is the rule of ethical truth, the standard of right and wrong, a sovereign, irreversible, absolute authority in the presence of men and Angels... This law, as apprehended in the minds of individual men, is called “conscience”; and though it may suffer refraction in passing into the intellectual medium of each, it is not therefore so affected as to lose its character of being the Divine Law, but still has, as such, the prerogative of commanding obedience.

Conscience is the aboriginal Vicar of Christ, a prophet in its informations, a monarch in its peremptoriness, a priest in its blessings and anathemas...

Conscience has rights because it has duties.

Certainly, if I am obliged to bring religion into after-dinner toasts, I shall drink — to the Pope, if you please, — still, to Conscience first, and to the Pope afterwards.

From An Essay in Aid of a Grammar of Assent (1870), ch. 5:**

If, as is the case, we feel responsibility, are ashamed, are frightened, at transgressing the voice of conscience, this implies there is One to whom we are responsible, before whom we are ashamed, whose claims upon us we fear.

And, in summary of his view: conscience reveals the existence of God — “an echo implies a voice, a voice a speaker, and that speaker I love and fear.” Newman understands conscience as innate and as working intuitively: we sense, rather than calculate, what the Divine Law demands in a particular situation.

Questions for study

Comprehension (AO1)

1. Explain Newman’s claim that conscience is “the echo of the voice of God,” paying attention to the chain “an echo implies a voice, a voice a speaker.”
2. How does Newman use the feelings of responsibility, shame and fear as evidence for the existence of God?

Analysis (AO2)

1. Newman’s argument moves from inner moral experience to an external divine Person. Analyse the structure of this inference: what *kind* of argument is it, and what must be granted for it to succeed?
2. “Conscience has rights because it has duties.” Analyse what Newman compresses into this epigram, and how it separates genuine conscience from a mere wish to do as one pleases.
3. Newman calls conscience “a prophet... a monarch... a priest.” Analyse what each image adds to his picture of conscience’s authority.

Synthesis (AO1/AO2)

1. Newman reads guilt, shame and the sense of being watched as pointing to God; Freud reads exactly these phenomena as the work of the super-ego (Topic 6). Stage the confrontation: whose interpretation of the shared evidence is stronger?
2. Newman (“to Conscience first”) and the Catechism §1790 (Topic 2) both place conscience above external authority. Is Newman more radical than the Magisterium, or are they saying the same thing?

Evaluation (AO2)

1. “Newman’s conscience is merely Freud’s super-ego with a halo.” Evaluate this claim.

Examination-style essay (AO1 + AO2)

“The argument from conscience provides convincing evidence for the existence of God.”
Discuss with reference to Newman.

Part II — Conscience as Reason: The Scholastic Account

4. Thomas Aquinas — *Synderesis*, *Conscientia* and the Erring Conscience

One of the two scholars named in the OCR specification.

Introduction

Thomas Aquinas (1225–1274), the Dominican friar whose *Summa Theologica* is the architecture of Catholic moral theology, holds the position that conscience is, fundamentally, an operation of **reason** — not a special organ, not a feeling, and emphatically not a voice. This single commitment is what sets him against almost everyone else in this anthology, and especially against Freud (Topic 6), for whom conscience is precisely a non-rational deposit of feeling and authority. Get the architecture right and the rest follows.

Aquinas builds conscience from three components, all of which the specification names. **Ratio** is reason itself, placed in every person as a consequence of being made in the image of God; it is the faculty by which we know moral truth at all. **Synderesis** is not a power but a *disposition* (a settled orientation) of practical reason: the innate, unshakeable grasp of the first principle of all moral action — that good is to be done and pursued, and evil avoided. Synderesis “incites to good and complains of evil,” and, crucially, it cannot err. **Conscientia** — conscience in the strict sense — is then an *act*: the application of that general knowledge to a particular situation here and now. And because application requires reasoning about facts and circumstances, conscientia *can* err, even though synderesis cannot. This is Aquinas master-thought: **moral error enters at the level of application, never at the level of the first principle**. A man may know with perfect certainty that evil is to be avoided, and still, through faulty reasoning or false belief, conclude that some good act is evil, or some evil act good.

From this flows his demanding teaching on the **erring conscience**, the part of his thought the textbooks most often blur. Aquinas argues two things that sit together uneasily. First, one is *always* bound to follow one’s conscience: “every will at variance with reason, whether right or erring, is always evil.” To act against what you sincerely judge to be right is to will what you take to be evil, and that is always a fault. Second, following an erring conscience does *not* automatically make the act good. Everything turns on the source of the error. If the ignorance is **invincible** — ignorance you could not reasonably have overcome — you are excused. If it is **vincible** — ignorance that is your own fault, that more care or honesty would have dispelled — then you are culpable, and you sin even while “following your conscience.” The unsettling upshot is that a person with a vincibly mistaken conscience appears trapped: to act against conscience is wrong, but to act on a culpably mistaken conscience is also wrong. Aquinas’s reply is not to dissolve the trap but to point past it — the duty is to *form* one’s conscience, so that the error does not arise.

The text

From Aquinas, Summa Theologica, First Part, Treatise on Man (Q. 79), trans. R. J. Regan:

Synderesis is a characteristic disposition rather than a power... as nature needs to implant in us the first principles concerning theoretical matters, so also does nature need to implant in us the first principles concerning practical matters... and we call this disposition *synderesis*. And so we also say *synderesis* incites to good and complains of evil, since we progress from

first principles to discovery and judge about the things we have discovered... so we judge by both reason and *synderesis*.

Conscience (*conscientia*) is an act, not a power. And this is evident both from the naming of the word and from the things that we in our ordinary way of speaking attribute to conscience. It signifies the relation of knowledge to something else, since we define *conscience* as knowledge *with* something else. But acts connect knowledge with things. And so it is clear from the meaning of the word that conscience is an act.

We say that conscience bears witness, morally obliges or stirs to action, and accuses or disquiets or reproves. And all of these things result from connecting some knowledge of ours to what we do. This connection arises in three ways. It arises in one way as we recognize that we have or have not done something... and we accordingly say that conscience *bears witness*. In a second way, we connect our knowledge to something as we by our conscience judge that we should or should not do something; and we accordingly say that conscience *incites to action or morally obliges*. In a third way, we connect our knowledge to something as we by our conscience judge that we have or have not done something worthily; and we accordingly say that conscience *excuses, or accuses and disquiets*.

From Aquinas, Summa Theologica, First Part of the Second Part (I-II), Q. 19, a. 5, on whether the will is evil when at variance with an erring reason:

We must therefore conclude that, absolutely speaking, every will at variance with reason, whether right or erring, is always evil.

Specification note. The OCR-named ideas map onto these texts as follows: **ratio** = reason, placed in us as God's image, by which we know moral truth; **synderesis** = the innate disposition orienting us to good and away from evil (it cannot err); **conscientia** = the act of applying that knowledge to a particular case (it can err); **invincible ignorance** = error for which a person is not responsible (excused); **vincible ignorance** = error for which a person is responsible (culpable).

Questions for study

Comprehension (AO1)

1. Distinguish *synderesis* from *conscientia*: which is a disposition and which is an act, and which of the two can err?
2. State the three ways in which, according to Aquinas, conscience connects our knowledge to what we do.

Analysis (AO2)

1. Aquinas places error at the level of *conscientia* but not *synderesis*. Analyse how this division lets him hold, without contradiction, that the basic moral sense is infallible while individuals constantly go wrong.
2. Analyse the reasoning behind "every will at variance with reason, whether right or erring, is always evil." Why does acting *against* a mistaken conscience still amount to willing evil?
3. Analyse the distinction between *vincible* and *invincible* ignorance, and the moral work it performs: how can two people who follow equally mistaken consciences differ in guilt?

Synthesis (AO1/AO2)

1. Aquinas makes conscience an act of *reason*; Freud makes it a deposit of feeling and authority in the *unconscious* (Topic 6). Compare them as rival accounts of the same word and locate the precise point of incompatibility.
2. The Catechism §1790 (Topic 2) and Newman's toast (Topic 3) both inherit Aquinas's "follow even an erring conscience." Do they preserve his doctrine intact, or quietly soften it?
3. Butler grounds morality in the "natural supremacy of conscience" (Topic 5). Compare this with Aquinas's *synderesis*: is Butler, in effect, offering a secularised Thomism?

Evaluation (AO2)

1. "Aquinas leaves the person of vincibly mistaken conscience condemned whether they act on it or against it." Evaluate whether this is a fatal flaw or a coherent demand that we take responsibility for forming our conscience.
2. Assess the objection that making conscience an act of reason cannot explain moral *motivation* — the felt pull of conscience that Newman and Freud both stress.
3. Evaluate whether *synderesis* — the innate grasp that "good is to be done and evil avoided" — is genuinely informative, or an empty formula that tells no one what to actually do.

Examination-style essay (AO1 + AO2)

"Aquinas's account of conscience is more convincing than Freud's." Discuss.

Part III — Conscience as Inner Authority: The Philosophical Tradition

5. Joseph Butler — The Natural Supremacy of Conscience

A “beyond the specification” source. Butler is the classic English philosophical theory of conscience and an exceptionally productive comparison with both Aquinas and Freud.

Introduction

Joseph Butler (1692–1752), Bishop of Durham, delivered his *Fifteen Sermons Preached at the Rolls Chapel* (1726) as a sustained argument about the structure of human nature — and they remain among the most admired works of English moral philosophy. Butler is technically a clergyman, but his method is philosophical, not scriptural: he asks us to look at how a human being is actually *constituted* and to read our moral obligations off that constitution.

His picture is hierarchical. At the bottom are the **particular passions and appetites** — hunger, anger, curiosity — each aimed at its own object. Above them stand two **general principles**: *self-love*, which aims at our own long-term good, and *benevolence*, which aims at the good of others. (Butler’s insistence that benevolence is as natural as self-love is a deliberate refutation of Hobbes’s claim that we are moved only by self-interest.) And above everything sits **conscience**, which Butler also calls the *principle of reflection*: the faculty by which we survey our own passions and actions and pronounce some right and others wrong. Conscience does not merely *compete* with the passions as one more impulse; it occupies a different rank. It is meant “to preside and govern.”

Butler’s single most important — and most examinable — move is his distinction between the **authority** and the **power** of conscience. Conscience has supreme *authority*: it is built into our nature to rule, and its right to direct us does not depend on its being strong enough to do so. But it frequently lacks *power*: a fierce appetite may overwhelm it in the moment. This is why Butler can say that conscience plainly *ought* to govern, while conceding that in fact it often does not — and it is the source of his most quoted sentence: “Had it strength, as it has right; had it power, as it has manifest authority, it would absolutely govern the world.” The distinction is elegant and does real work, but it also marks the place where Butler is most vulnerable. He shows, at best, that conscience has authority *within our psychology*; he does not obviously show that its particular verdicts are *correct*. And the whole edifice leans on a providential premise — that our nature was designed, by a good God, so that conscience tracks the good. Remove that premise, as Darwin (Topic 9) and Freud (Topic 6) effectively do, and the question returns with force: why trust the magistrate within?

The text

From Joseph Butler, Fifteen Sermons Preached at the Rolls Chapel (1726), Sermons on human nature and the natural supremacy of conscience:**

Had it strength, as it has right; had it power, as it has manifest authority, it would absolutely govern the world.

In Butler’s account: there is in every person a superior principle of reflection, or conscience, which distinguishes between the inward principles of the heart as well as outward actions, and passes judgement upon them — pronouncing some just, right and good, and others evil, wrong and unjust. By the “very constitution” of human nature, this principle is set over the others; it belongs to

conscience to *preside and govern*. To act in accordance with conscience is therefore to act in accordance with our true nature; to be ruled by a passion against conscience is to invert the proper order of the self, even when the passion happens to win.

Questions for study

Comprehension (AO1)

1. Explain Butler's distinction between the *authority* and the *power* of conscience.
2. What does Butler mean by claiming that conscience would "absolutely govern the world" if its power matched its right?

Analysis (AO2)

1. Analyse how the authority/power distinction explains both *why* we ought to obey conscience and *why* we so often fail to.
2. Butler derives the supremacy of conscience from "the very constitution of man." Analyse this inference: what does it assume about human nature and its origin?

Synthesis (AO1/AO2)

1. Compare Butler's "natural supremacy of conscience" with Aquinas's *synderesis* (Topic 4). Two rational, authoritative consciences — where do they agree, and where part?
2. Butler grounds conscience's authority in a providentially designed nature; Darwin (Topic 9) offers a designer-free account of how that same "constitution" arose. Does Butler's premise survive Darwin's challenge?

Evaluation (AO2)

1. "Butler shows that conscience has authority; he never shows that its judgements are true." Evaluate.

Examination-style essay (AO1 + AO2)

"Conscience has authority but no power." Assess Butler's account of the moral life.

Part IV — Conscience Without God: Psychological and Developmental Accounts

The thinkers in Parts I–III disagree about much, but they agree that conscience is, in some sense, *authoritative* — a voice worth obeying, whether because it is God’s, or reason’s, or our true nature’s. Part IV breaks with that consensus. Here conscience is something to be *explained* rather than obeyed: a deposit of childhood (Freud), a possibly-distorted internalisation of authority (Fromm), or a stage in cognitive growth (Piaget, Kohlberg). The question silently shifts from “what does conscience command?” to “what *is* this thing, and can we trust it at all?”

6. Sigmund Freud — Conscience as the Super-Ego

Introduction

Sigmund Freud (1856–1939),¹ the Viennese founder of psychoanalysis, produced the most influential *deflationary* theory of conscience ever advanced — deflationary because it offers to explain the whole phenomenon without remainder, and without God. Before Freud, conscience was something you consulted; after Freud, it is something you diagnose.

Freud’s early model divided the mind into the **conscious** and the vast **unconscious**, the repository of everything our “conditioning does not allow us to look at.” From 1923 (*The Ego and the Id*) he overlaid a second, *structural* model of three agencies. The **id** (Freud’s term was *das Es*, “the It”) is the primitive, wholly unconscious reservoir of instinctual drives we are born with; it obeys the **pleasure principle**, demands immediate gratification, and is “completely amoral.” The **ego** (*das Ich*, “the I”) develops out of the id to deal with reality; governed by the **reality principle**, it is rational, practical, and engaged in “reality testing,” mediating between the id’s demands and the world. And the **super-ego** (*das Über-Ich*, “the Over-I”) is the “inner parent” — and *this*, Freud says, is conscience.

For the examination, three implications matter, and each overturns a claim made earlier in this anthology. First, conscience is **heteronomous**: its contents are introjected from outside — from parents, and through them from society and tradition — so that “following your conscience” may be nothing grander than obeying an internalised father. This directly contradicts the rational autonomy of Aquinas and Butler and the divine voice of Newman. Second, conscience is the **heir to the Oedipus complex**: it forms as the child represses forbidden desires and identifies with the same-sex parent, which is why Freud ties moral development to *psychosexual* development. Third, and most provocatively, the super-ego is frequently **punitive and irrational** — it can be “severe,” “humiliating” the ego with “dire punishments” — so that guilt is often a symptom to be treated rather than a signpost to be trusted. The aim of analysis is “to strengthen the ego and make it more independent of the super-ego.” Where Newman hears God in the voice of guilt, Freud hears a harsh parent who should, sometimes, be defied.

The source anthology itself records the standard objections — that Freud over-emphasises sex, and that his claims to be scientific sit awkwardly with vague findings drawn from small samples — and you should press them hard in evaluation.

The text

From Ruth Snowden, Freud: The Key Ideas* (McGraw-Hill, 2006), with the source anthology's summary:*

In 1923 Freud published his book *The Ego and the Id*, which proposed a new dynamic model of the mind... It involved three main parts: the id, ego and super-ego. These are not really physical parts of the brain but represent different aspects of the way we think, and so help to explain the apparent battle that goes on between different levels of consciousness.

Id: the unconscious part of the psyche that is concerned with inherited, instinctive impulses. **Ego:** the part of the psyche which reacts to external reality and which a person thinks of as the “self.” **Super-ego:** the part of the psyche that acts like an “inner parent,” giving us a conscience and responding to social rules.

[*The id*] From the Latin word for “it,” the id is the primitive, unconscious part of the mind that we are born with... It is a dark, inaccessible area, seething with instinctive urges and its only reality is its own selfish needs. It is the source of the motive force behind the pleasure principle... The id is disorganized and illogical in nature... It can make no value judgements — it is completely amoral.

[*The ego*] Named from the Latin word for “I,” the ego is the part of the mind that reacts to external reality and which a person thinks of as the “self”... It is practical and rational, involved in decision making. Anxiety arises from the ego... A whole system of unconscious defence mechanisms protects the ego... The main function of the ego is that of reality testing: it replaces the primitive pleasure principle of the id with a new reality principle... Freud compares the ego and the id with a rider and his horse. The horse supplies the motor energy, but the rider decides where to go.

[*The super-ego*] In each of us there is an agency that observes our behaviour and threatens to punish us — a sort of inner grown-up... This is how the super-ego develops: gradually a sort of inner parent evolves and the child develops feelings of guilt and of being watched and controlled. One aspect of this super-ego is what we would call the conscience — the part of ourselves that tells us what is right and what is wrong and judges our behaviour accordingly... It gives us our sense of right and wrong, pride and guilt... The super-ego incorporates the teachings of the past and of tradition... It can be quite severe with the poor ego, humiliating it, ill-treating it and threatening it with dire punishments... The super-ego develops as the Oedipus complex begins to be resolved... The intention of psychoanalysis is really to strengthen the ego and make it more independent of the super-ego.

Questions for study

Comprehension (AO1)

1. Distinguish the id, ego and super-ego: for each, say *what it is*, *what it does*, and *where it comes from*.
2. Explain the difference between the pleasure principle and the reality principle.
3. According to Freud, how does the super-ego develop, and what is its relation to the Oedipus complex and to the child's parents?

Analysis (AO2)

1. Freud calls the super-ego an “inner parent.” Analyse what follows from deriving conscience from internalised parental authority rather than from reason or revelation.
2. The super-ego operates largely unconsciously and can be “severe,” even “ill-treating” the ego. Analyse what this implies for the trustworthiness of feelings of guilt.
3. Analyse the rider-and-horse analogy: what does it claim about the relation between reason and instinct, and about how much genuine control the self possesses?

Synthesis (AO1/AO2)

1. Aquinas makes conscience a rational act that can be *formed and corrected*; Freud makes it an unconscious residue largely beyond rational control (Topic 4). What hangs, practically, on this disagreement?

Evaluation (AO2)

1. “To explain where conscience comes from is not to show that its judgements are false.” Evaluate this (genetic-fallacy) reply to Freud.
2. Assess the scientific status of the theory of the super-ego: is it testable, and does the available evidence support it?
3. Evaluate the claim that Freud’s account, if true, makes “follow your conscience” dangerous advice.

Examination-style essay (AO1 + AO2)

“Freud successfully shows that conscience is nothing more than the super-ego.” Discuss.

7. Piaget, Kohlberg and Gilligan — The Development of Moral Reasoning

This is empirical moral psychology rather than a theory of conscience as such — but it offers a powerful third option, against both the theological “innate voice” and Freud’s affective super-ego.

Introduction

Where Freud made conscience a matter of *feeling* fixed early by the Oedipus complex, the cognitive-developmental tradition of Jean Piaget (1896–1980) and Lawrence Kohlberg (1927–1987) makes it a matter of *reasoning* that grows in stages across childhood and adolescence. This is the second great internal debate of Part IV: **affect versus cognition** as the engine of the moral self. Kohlberg drew the contrast deliberately, distinguishing his view from Freud’s; if he is right, conscience is less an inner parent than an inner logician, maturing as the capacity for abstract thought matures.

Piaget, studying children playing marbles, found a shift from **moral heteronomy** (or *moral realism*) — in which rules are experienced as fixed, external and unchangeable, and blame is reckoned by the *amount of damage* rather than the *intention* — to **moral autonomy**, in which rules are understood as conventions formed by mutual consent and revisable, and intention becomes central. Kohlberg expanded these two stages into **six**, grouped in three levels: **pre-conventional** (morality as avoiding punishment and seeking reward), **conventional** (morality as social approval and law-and-order), and **post-conventional** (morality as social contract and, finally, self-chosen universal principles). He probed these with moral dilemmas, most famously “Heinz and the drug,” caring not whether children judged Heinz right or wrong but *how they reasoned*.

For the examiner, four critical fault-lines matter, and the source article — admirably even-handed — lays them out. (1) **Cognition versus affect**: Kohlberg’s stages stress reasoning, but moral judgement is also moved by emotion. (2) **Understanding versus action**: knowing the good is not doing it; “the power of the situation” often overrides abstract principle. (3) **Cultural variation**: Kohlberg claimed universality, yet his post-conventional stages encode a Western, Enlightenment, *individualist* ideal that fits collectivist cultures poorly. (4) **Gender**: Kohlberg’s original sample was all-male, and Carol Gilligan (b. 1936) argued that the whole tradition — Freud, Piaget, Kohlberg — mistook a *different* female moral voice (an ethic of *care* and relationship) for a deficient one (a weaker ethic of *justice*). Handle Gilligan with the source’s own care: it notes Eliot Turiel’s rejoinder that Gilligan “imposes certainty where ambiguity exists,” and the later empirical literature finds the care/justice gender split smaller and less consistent than *A Different Voice* implied. The deepest question this section raises is philosophical, not psychological, and the essay at the end presses it: even a perfect account of how moral reasoning *develops* would not, by itself, tell us which moral judgements are *true*.

The text

From J. S. Fleming, “Piaget, Kohlberg, Gilligan, and Others on Moral Development” (abbreviated):

Piaget’s two stages.

Piaget found that younger children (around ages four to seven) thought in terms of moral realism or moral heteronomy. These terms connote an absolutism, in which morality is seen in terms of rules that are fixed and unchangeable... Guilt is determined by the extent of violation of rules rather than by intention. The second stage... comes later, usually around age 10, when children come to realize that rules have arbitrariness and are formed

by mutual consent for reasons of fairness and equity... Piaget called this second stage moral autonomy.

Piaget's method — a sample dialogue (a child judging two boys who broke teacups):

Q: Is one of the boys naughtier than the other? — A: The first is, because he knocked over twelve cups. [...] Q: If it was you who had broken the twelve cups... and your little sister who had broken one cup when she was trying to get the jam, which of you would be punished more severely? — A: Me, because I broke more than one cup.

Kohlberg's "Heinz" dilemma.

In Europe, a woman was near death from a special kind of cancer. There was one drug that the doctors thought might save her... The druggist was charging ten times what the drug cost him to make... The sick woman's husband, Heinz, went to everyone he knew to borrow the money, but he could only get together about half of what it cost... So Heinz got desperate and broke into the man's store to steal the drug for his wife. Should the husband have done that?

Kohlberg's levels and stages.

Level I: Preconventional Morality. The preconventional child thinks of morality in terms of the consequences of disobedience to adult rules in order to avoid punishment... *Stage 1* — "punishment and obedience"... *Stage 2* — "instrumentalism," "what's in it for me"; the child recognizes mutual benefit in cooperation on a "tit-for-tat" basis.

Level II: Conventional Morality. The child begins to grasp social rules and gains a more objective perspective on right and wrong. Freud would equate this level with superego development, or the formation of a conscience... *Stage 3* — "interpersonal relationships," "good girl / boy"; the motive is social approval. *Stage 4* — "law and order"; the concept of "doing one's duty" is crucial.

Level III: Postconventional Morality. The emphasis is no longer on conventional, societal standards but on personal or idealized principles. *Stage 5* — "social contract"; laws are for the mutual benefit of all and unjust laws ought to be changed. *Stage 6* — "universal ethical principles"; right and wrong are determined by individual reflection on what is proper... One might think here of Kant's categorical imperative... Kohlberg believed that few people actually reach this stage, but those who do are of the stature of Mohandas Gandhi or Martin Luther King, Jr.

Gilligan on Freud.

Having tied the formation of the superego or conscience to castration anxiety, Freud considered women to be deprived by nature of the impetus for a clear-cut Oedipal resolution. Consequently, women's superego... was compromised... From this observation of difference... Freud concluded that women "show less sense of justice than men, that they are less ready to submit to the great exigencies of life, that they are more often influenced in their judgments by feelings of affection and hostility."

Questions for study

Comprehension (AO1)

1. Explain Piaget's distinction between moral heteronomy and moral autonomy: at roughly what ages does each appear, and how does that relate to conscience?
2. Outline Kohlberg's three levels and six stages of moral development.
3. Summarise Gilligan's two main objections to Kohlberg.

Analysis (AO2)

1. Kohlberg cared not whether children judged Heinz right or wrong but about their *reasoning*. Analyse why the structure of reasoning, rather than the verdict, is significant for conscience.

Synthesis (AO1/AO2)

1. Freud locates conscience in early childhood and in feeling; Piaget and Kohlberg locate it across childhood and adolescence and in reasoning (Topic 6). Which theory better captures what conscience is?
2. Piaget and Kohlberg make conscience *developed*; Aquinas's *synderesis* and Newman's "echo of God's voice" make it *innate* (Topics 3–4). Can these be reconciled, or must one side be mistaken?

Evaluation (AO2)

1. Assess whether a developmental psychology of moral *reasoning* can establish anything about whether our moral judgements are *true*.

Examination-style essay (AO1 + AO2)

"A theory of how moral reasoning develops tells us nothing about what is morally right."
Discuss with reference to Piaget and Kohlberg.

Part V — Conscience as Evolved: The Naturalistic Challenge

9. Charles Darwin — The Moral Sense as Social Instinct

Darwin mounts the most fundamental challenge to the whole theological tradition — and, properly understood, may not be its enemy.

Introduction

Charles Darwin (1809–1882) devoted two chapters of *The Descent of Man* (1871) to the origin of the moral sense, and what he proposed is the boldest claim in this anthology: that conscience is neither implanted by God nor a special faculty of the soul, but the *natural and inevitable* outcome of evolution. Give a social animal well-marked social instincts, and then give it intelligence enough to reflect, remember and anticipate, and a conscience will appear of its own accord. No designer, no revelation, and no Oedipus complex is required.

The mechanism is worth grasping precisely, because it lets Darwin explain the very phenomenon Newman built his argument on — *remorse*. Social instincts (sympathy, the pleasure of others' company, the desire for their approval) are *enduring and general*; bodily appetites (hunger, lust, momentary anger) are *strong but fleeting*. When a creature capable of memory yields to a passing appetite and so violates its social instincts, the enduring instinct reasserts itself afterwards, and the resulting dissatisfaction *is* what we call guilt or remorse. Conscience, on this view, is the felt pressure of our social nature reviewed by our reason. Where Newman hears in remorse the echo of God's voice, and Freud the scolding of an internalised father, Darwin hears the persistence of an instinct selected because it helped our ancestors survive in groups.

This is a genuine challenge to every Part of this booklet, and a student should feel its force before answering it. It naturalises Newman's "echo," dissolves Butler's providential premise (the "constitution of man" is the work of natural selection, not benevolent design), and reframes Aquinas's God-given *ratio* as an evolved capacity. But notice two things that keep the debate open. First, Darwin's account is a theory of *origins*, and origins are not justifications: that a moral sense evolved tells us nothing, by itself, about whether its verdicts are *true* — the old gap between "is" and "ought." Second, Darwin's mechanism is compatible with theism: a believer can hold that God created *through* evolution, making natural selection the means and God the author, so that Darwin describes the *how* and leaves the *why* untouched. Whether that reconciliation is satisfying, or a hopeful evasion, is exactly what the evaluation questions ask you to decide.

The text

From Charles Darwin, The Descent of Man (1871), on the moral sense:**

I fully subscribe to the judgment of those writers who maintain that of all the differences between man and the lower animals, the moral sense or conscience is by far the most important.

The following proposition seems to me in a high degree probable — namely, that any animal whatever, endowed with well-marked social instincts... would inevitably acquire a moral sense or conscience, as soon as its intellectual powers had become as well, or nearly as well developed, as in man.

...the social instincts lead an animal to take pleasure in the society of its fellows, to feel a certain amount of sympathy with them, and to perform various services for them.

Questions for study

Comprehension (AO1)

1. State Darwin's central thesis: which two ingredients, combined, "inevitably" produce a moral sense or conscience?
2. According to Darwin, what do the "social instincts" do, and how do they differ from momentary appetites?

Analysis (AO2)

1. Analyse how Darwin proposes to explain remorse and guilt without God, and how this competes with Aquinas' argument (Topic 3).
2. Analyse whether Darwin's genealogy is intended to *debunk* conscience or merely to *explain* it — and whether the difference matters.

Synthesis (AO1/AO2)

1. Newman: remorse is the echo of God. Freud: remorse is the super-ego. Darwin: remorse is the reassertion of a social instinct (Topics 3, 6). Set the three genealogies of guilt side by side: which is most economical, and which most adequate?
2. Aquinas makes Reason the image of God; Darwin makes it an evolved adaptation (Topic 4). Are these rivals, or can "God created through evolution" hold them together?

Evaluation (AO2)

1. "Darwin explains where conscience comes from, but not whether it is right." Evaluate this objection with reference to the is/ought problem.
2. Evaluate the claim that evolution can account for in-group cooperation but not the universal, self-sacrificial morality of Kohlberg's stage 6 or of the command to love one's enemies (Topic 8).

Examination-style essay (AO1 + AO2)

"Conscience is fully explained as a product of evolution." Discuss.

Synoptic and Comparative Essays

1. “Conscience is innate, not acquired.” Discuss. (*Aquinas and Newman against Freud, Piaget, Kohlberg and Darwin.*)
2. “We should never disobey our conscience.” Discuss. (*Aquinas on the erring conscience, Newman and the Catechism against Freud’s punitive super-ego.*)
3. “A scientific account of conscience leaves no room for God.” Discuss. (*Freud and Darwin against the theistic-evolution reply.*)
4. “Aquinas and Freud cannot both be right about conscience.” Discuss. (*The two named scholars, head-to-head.*)

Glossary of Key Terms

AO1 (Assessment Objective 1) — In OCR Religious Studies, the demonstration of knowledge and understanding: accurate selection of material and correct use of technical vocabulary. Corresponds to *comprehension* in this booklet.

AO2 (Assessment Objective 2) — The analysis and evaluation of beliefs and arguments, including their significance and coherence. Carries the greater weight in every essay. Corresponds to *analysis*, *synthesis* and *evaluation* here.

Authoritarian conscience — Fromm's term for conscience as the internalised voice of external authority, obeyed from fear of and admiration for that authority; effectively a renaming of Freud's super-ego.

Autonomy / Heteronomy — Self-rule versus rule-from-without. In Piaget, the mature stage in which rules are seen as revisable conventions (autonomy) versus the earlier stage in which they are fixed and external (heteronomy). In Kant, the mark of a genuinely moral will.

Conscientia — In Aquinas, conscience in the strict sense: the *act* of applying moral knowledge to a particular situation. It can err. (Contrast *synderesis*.)

Conventional morality — Kohlberg's middle level (Stages 3–4): morality as social approval (“good boy / girl”) and as law-and-order duty.

Defence mechanism — In Freud, an unconscious strategy (e.g. repression) by which the ego protects itself from anxiety and unacceptable impulses.

Ego — In Freud, the reality-oriented “I” that mediates between the id, the super-ego and the external world, governed by the reality principle.

Ethic of care — Gilligan's account of a moral orientation centred on relationship, responsibility and response to need, which she argued the justice-centred tradition (Freud, Piaget, Kohlberg) had wrongly treated as inferior.

Eternal law / Natural law — In the Thomist tradition, the rational order of God's governance (eternal law) and the rational creature's participation in it (natural law); the framework within which *synderesis* and *conscientia* operate.

Gaudium et Spes — The *Pastoral Constitution on the Church in the Modern World* (Second Vatican Council, 1965), which calls conscience “man's most secret core and his sanctuary.”

Genetic fallacy — The error of judging the truth or value of a belief by its origin. Frequently invoked against Freud and Darwin: explaining where conscience comes from does not, by itself, show its judgements false.

Humanistic conscience — Fromm's term for conscience as the voice of one's true self, oriented to human flourishing and independent of external reward and punishment.

Id — In Freud, the primitive, wholly unconscious reservoir of instinctual drives, present at birth and governed by the pleasure principle; “completely amoral.”

Invincible ignorance — In the Thomist account, ignorance a person could not reasonably have overcome; it *excuses*, so acting on a conscience mistaken through invincible ignorance is not culpable.

Is/ought problem (Hume); Naturalistic fallacy (Moore) — The objection that one cannot validly derive a moral conclusion (“ought”) from purely factual premises (“is”); central to evaluating Darwin and all naturalistic accounts of conscience.

Magisterium — The teaching authority of the Roman Catholic Church.

Moral realism — In Piaget (a different sense from the metaethical term), the young child’s view that rules are fixed, external and unchangeable, with blame measured by damage rather than intention.

Oedipus complex — In Freud, the child’s repressed desire for the opposite-sex parent and rivalry with the same-sex parent; its resolution, through identification, forms the super-ego.

Pleasure principle / Reality principle — In Freud, the id’s demand for immediate gratification versus the ego’s capacity to defer gratification in the light of reality.

Postconventional morality — Kohlberg’s highest level (Stages 5–6): morality as social contract and, ultimately, self-chosen universal ethical principles.

Preconventional morality — Kohlberg’s first level (Stages 1–2): morality as the avoidance of punishment and the pursuit of reward.

Principle of reflection — Butler’s name for conscience: the superior faculty that surveys and judges our passions and actions, possessing natural authority over them.

Psychoanalysis — The system of psychology founded by Freud, centred on the unconscious mind and its influence on behaviour.

Ratio — In Aquinas, reason itself, placed in every person as a consequence of being made in the image of God; the faculty by which moral truth is known.

Repression — In Freud, the unconscious exclusion of unacceptable impulses or memories from awareness.

Social instinct — In Darwin, the inherited disposition of social animals to seek the company of, sympathise with and serve their fellows; the raw material from which conscience evolves.

Super-ego — In Freud, the “inner parent”: the internalised authority of parents and society that functions as conscience, generating guilt and the sense of being watched.

Synderesis — In Aquinas, the innate *disposition* of practical reason that grasps the first moral principle (do good, avoid evil) and “incites to good and complains of evil.” It cannot err. (Contrast *conscientia*.)

Vincible ignorance — In the Thomist account, ignorance a person could and should have overcome; it does *not* excuse, so acting on a conscience mistaken through vincible ignorance remains culpable.